

Environmental Justice Campaign Starter Kit

Fight a toxic facility, pollution source, or discriminatory land-use decision in your community.

Step 1 — Document the Harm

- Gather community health data: asthma, cancer, chronic illness rates, complaints to health dept.
- Use EPA EJScreen (ejscreen.epa.gov) to show your community's cumulative environmental burden score.
- Map pollution sources using EPA's Facility Registry System (FRS) and Toxic Release Inventory (TRI).
- Take air quality readings with Purple Air monitors or rent from local environmental groups.
- Collect community testimony: who got sick, when, what they reported, to whom.

Step 2 — File Regulatory Complaints

EPA Civil Rights	File under Title VI — agencies with federal funds cannot discriminate in pollution siting. epa.gov/ocr/filing-complaint
EPA TIP Hotline	Report violations: 1-800-424-4372
Virginia DEQ	deq.virginia.gov or (800) 592-5482
Maryland MDE	mde.maryland.gov/complaints
NC DEQ	deq.nc.gov/about/divisions/compliance

Step 3 — Legal Intervention Points

Stage	Intervention	How
Permit Application	Public Comment Period	Submit written comments. Organize hearings attendance.
Permit Issued	Administrative Appeal	Challenge within 30 days. Attorney required for formal challenges.
Operations	Citizen Suit	Clean Air Act § 304 and Clean Water Act § 505 allow citizen suits for violations.
Federal Agency Involved	NEPA Comment	Submit comments on Environmental Impact Statement.
Zoning Decision	City/County Appeal	Challenge discriminatory zoning within appeal windows.

Step 4 — Data Sources

Resource	What It Shows	URL
EPA EJScreen	EJ scores by location	ejscreen.epa.gov
EPA TRI	Toxic releases by facility	epa.gov/toxics-release-inventory-tri-program
EPA AQS	Air quality monitoring data	epa.gov/outdoor-air-quality-data
CDC PLACES	Community health data by zip	cdc.gov/places
ProPublica Cancer Map	Cancer risk from air pollution	propublica.org/article/toxmap

Step 5 — Coalition Building

- Identify health organizations, faith communities, schools, and community centers affected.
- Connect with: Earthjustice, WE ACT, NAACP Environmental & Climate Justice Program.
- Medical providers who can speak publicly about patient impacts are powerful coalition members.
- Investigative journalists: environmental + racial justice angle = high-interest story.

TIP: Strongest EJ argument = health data (what community suffers) + facility data (who is polluting) + demographic data (who lives near facility) in a single document.